



**SUNIL
KATKADE**
FARMER,
MAHARASHTRA

Katkade's life changed after he installed a micro sprinkler irrigation system on his farm and took to onion and vegetable farming in Naygaon, a village in Nashik. With higher yields and income, he has bought a jeep and more land.

Bangladesh. Conservative estimates state that individual farmers earn over Rs 5 lakh a year. Nomula Muthyam Reddy is one. He is just back from his son's graduation ceremony in the US. "These farmers through hard work and innovation have emerged as extraordinary wealth creators," says district collector B. Seetaramanajaneyulu.

Mritunjay Sharma, 42, is another who's literally minting money. He's recently added menthe oil (mint) to the crops on his farm in Chandauli village in Barabanki and the returns are already enough for him to consider buying a Honda City to replace the Maruti Swift he owns. Says Sharma: "Earlier, farm-

ers grew wheat and paddy but menthe oil has given us an added financial advantage." India is the largest producer and exporter of the oil which is grown between March-June, when farmers leave fields uncultivated to prepare for the monsoons. Hundreds of menthe oil units have sprung up in Barabanki. "One litre of the oil which is used in medicines, toothpastes, cosmetics earns a farmer around Rs 500 to Rs 575. One acre of land could produce 40 litres of menthe oil in three months and this has changed the grass-roots-level economy of the district.

In Madhya Pradesh, it's soyabean. When it started two years ago, soyabean was

SWITCHING TO NEW CROPS IS A MONEY SPINNER. Theni village SWITCHED TO GRAPE CULTIVATION ALLOWING IT TO COMPETE IN WORLD MARKETS WITH ITS THOMSON GRAPES.

